

KF24 Meeting Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

Please join with us by circulating your gifts. You can make a regular automatic donation through the KF website.

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

This week we will start learning another meditation practice. Our goal in this part of the meeting is simply to introduce different mindfulness and meditation techniques. During your meditation time, you can use a variety of practices, or you can choose one practice to suit your present need and state of mind. The meditation masters encourage us to stick with one method for a few years, and we can understand their reasons, but for the rest of this year, you might just practice the meditation of the month and explore what works for you. In this lesson we will look at a meditation practice called **Centering Prayer**, popularized by Father Thomas Keating.¹

In the **Centering Prayer** pamphlet, we read:

Centering Prayer is a method of silent prayer that prepares us to receive the gift of contemplative prayer, prayer in which we experience God's presence within us, closer than breathing, closer than thinking, closer than consciousness itself. This method of prayer is both a relationship with God and a discipline to foster that relationship.²

Centering Prayer

Begin with stillness, resting in your spirit and your natural breath. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause)* To straighten your neck, lift the back of your head and lower your chin a little. Reach the crown of your head toward the heavens and your tailbone toward the earth. You might try standing during this meditation time, which may help focus a wandering mind. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Now, try asking God for a word, a phrase, or an image. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* We will use the simple term *word* to refer to these words, phrases, and images. Some people identify a word like *love*, *mercy*, or *Jesus* or a meaningful image—for example, a waterfall or a bird in flight. You might choose a word of guidance like *let go* or *connect*. Allow your word to float to the surface of your consciousness and stick to it during

the meditation time. When other thoughts intrude into your consciousness, gently return to your word. Breathe, and allow your mind to rest in stillness as you continue to recall the word. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

When you are comfortable with your word, try allowing it to float away from your mind. Dwell in the silence and rest in the stillness as you simply observe your breathing. You might attend to the word for one breath and then allow your mind to repose silently for two breaths. We will practice for one minute. Remember to consciously breathe. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

During this last minute of meditation, we will let go of the word completely and allow our minds to rest in stillness as we observe the breath. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Take a fresh, deep breath as if you were stretching your insides. Gently open your eyes and re-engage with your environment.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?”)

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

This month we will turn our attention to KF Confession 6:

We chose to foster illusions to save the life of our Idol Self.

Before we get started with our Toolbox training, you might want to take out a **Two Paths Worksheet**. You will also need this worksheet for the Bible Teaching.

When you look at the **Two Paths Worksheet: Believing v. Judging**, perhaps you can see how far you have come in your training. This worksheet reminds us of how we used to live, with all of our stories, reactions, and mindlessness.

If we choose to live in the pride system, we are driven to maintain an artificial and legalistic state of being. Maintaining our pride system takes a lot of work and uses up tons of our precious energy, but it is work that we are used to. Powerful fear drives us, and we are lured into the hunter’s snare by the illusion that adhering to our pride system will save our lives. When we become aware of our fear and realize that we cannot use our pride system to escape the grip of fear, we can use W-A-A! (Words, Attitude, Action) and other KF tools to defuse the chaotic feelings of self-hate.³ Simply recognizing our fear can give us a moment to breathe instead of immediately reacting to an event. Use the **Two Paths Flowchart** regularly to look at what is happening in your life and allow yourself a moment to breathe before you act.

Now let’s review the **Two Paths Worksheet: Believing v. Judging**. You can actually start anywhere on this worksheet, but in this lesson we will begin with step 1, the outcome.

1. OUTCOME: What am I experiencing?

You will find this step under the Judgment Path. It’s often helpful to begin by exploring your outcome because most of the time you don’t know what led to that outcome. What are you experiencing right now? You might ask yourself: *Is my outcome demonstrating the love of God and supporting His purposes in this world?* If not, you are probably on the Judgment Path.

2. ACTION: What did I do or avoid that invited this outcome?

When you have observed the outcome, you can use the worksheet to trace your outcome back to its source. What choice did you make or what action did you take that led to the outcome? Or did you avoid a courageous choice or action?

3. REJOICING IN THE MISORIENTATION: What emotions did I experience that drove me to act?

The idea that you have rejoiced in misorientation can be difficult to understand at first. Misoriented emotions drive misoriented choices, so you might ask yourself: *Did I indulge in some kind of vindictive triumph? Did I delight in euphoria through self-indulgence or recklessness? Did I get caught up in illusions about myself or others? Did I relieve my tension in a rage to conclude? Did I act out of self-hate or the fear of hurt pride?*

4. THE STORY: What story did I tell that generated emotions?

Human beings are creative; we are designed to tell stories. The Idol Self hijacks that natural ability and uses storytelling to create an alternate reality. We all have a story about why we are the way we are, why we do what we do, and why we feel what we feel. Our stories justify our judgments, fuel our misoriented emotions, and support our pride system.

5. JUDGING AS GOOD OR EVIL: What was my short-tempered judgment?

What was your automatic reaction to the event or situation? Did you judge it as good or bad?

6. FEAR OF DEATH OR EUPHORIA: What standard of my Idol Self was threatened or fulfilled?

You might ask yourself: *What was dangerous or delirious about this event? How did it threaten or fulfill my search for an imagined glory?* You may now recognize what scared you or what, perhaps, relieved you of your fear of death.

After you have worked through steps 1–6, choose an intervention to help you gain more clarity about your reactions. You might wish to use the **Tapping Protocol**, mindfulness practices, or our next tool, the **T-A-T**, which we will explore in our next lesson.⁴ Then, use your creative imagination in an oriented way as you work up the left side of the worksheet taking the Believe It Path.

7. EVENT: What triggered the fear or the euphoria?

Perhaps at this stage you are able to identify what ignited the fuel in the cylinders of your self-hate engine or what temporarily fulfilled your idealized dreams of glory. What happened that sent you down the Judgment Path? Try to describe the event simply.

As you work through steps 8–12, use the beautiful gift of your imagination in a healthy way to help you take the Believe It Path and plan a course that could create an opportunity for oriented, productive outcomes. The KF Compass and the **Expanded Version** of this Toolbox contain Nancy's instructions for navigating these steps.

You already know that extreme outbursts, irritations, anxieties, self-sabotage, hurts, depression, forcing things, and shutting down are all symptoms of the self-hate that drives each of us back into slavery to the Idol. But you really can look at self-hate with compassion even when you are feeling its compelling invitations. You can courageously observe what is going on, learn to manage yourself, and, eventually, grow out of self-hate.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Holy Spirit, guide me to defuse the power of my self-hate. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

Let's listen once again to KF Confession 6:

We chose to foster illusions to save the life of our Idol Self.

This month we will look at our illusions about life, others, and ourselves—illusions that we ferociously defend in order to protect our pride. In the midst of our anxiety and chaotic choices, we have learned to depend on our pride as a substitute for real self-confidence. When things fall apart, we get a marvelous chance to examine our pride and our attachments.

Let's look at an event in the lives of John the Baptist's disciples and examine it through the lens of the **Two Paths Worksheet**. Here is Nancy's paraphrase of **John 3:22–30**.

²²After these things Jesus and his disciples went into the land of Judea, and He was spending time with them and baptizing (which is symbolic of purification). ²³John was also baptizing in Aenon near Salim since there was lots of water there, and people were coming to be baptized. ²⁴This was before John had been thrown into prison. ²⁵In the midst of this baptizing, John's disciples initiated a discussion with a Jew about purification. ²⁶Then they came to John and said to him, "Rabbi, He who was with you on the other side of the Jordan, the one that you endorsed—just look at Him! He is baptizing and all are coming to Him." ²⁷John answered and said, "No one is capable of receiving anything like purification unless it is granted to them from heaven. So, it really doesn't matter who they go to for purification. ²⁸By the way, you yourselves can endorse me—I have already told you that I, myself, am not the Christ, but that I have been sent ahead of Him. ²⁹The same principle of purification applies to marriage rites. It's not about the one who does the purifying but about the one who has the bride—that is, the bridegroom. The friend of the bridegroom who stands by and hears him greatly rejoices in the bridegroom's voice because he is not envious or desiring his place. Therefore, my mission as friend is completed, and this makes me full of joy. ³⁰The bridegroom is the one who must be brought to manhood, and I, myself, must recede from the scene."

Take a deep breath.

To give us a deeper understanding of this story, we will now use the **Two Paths Worksheet**. We can start with step 7 because this passage describes the event. We will follow John's disciples as they take the Judgment Path, and we will see that at step 2, the point of action, these well-trained disciples apply what they have learned: they switch paths, get creative, and make an oriented choice.

7. EVENT: What triggered the fear or the euphoria?

Jesus is becoming more popular than John, and in this passage we see two very different reactions to

that same event. How is it that John takes the Believe It Path, but his disciples take the Judgment Path?

6. FEAR OF DEATH OR EUPHORIA: What standard of my Idol Self was threatened or fulfilled?

What do the disciples fear? They are obviously in a rage to conclude the tension created by their leader's declining influence. They want John to do something about their tension. We don't know exactly what they fear, but John's disciples suddenly see their search for glory disappearing into the mist, and they feel anxious.

5. JUDGING AS GOOD OR EVIL: What was my short-tempered judgment?

We have been conditioned to judge as evil any event that triggers our fear. In this passage, we see that the disciples judge as bad the decline of their ministry.

4. STORY: What story did I tell that generated emotions?

John's disciples seem to be judging Jesus and blaming John. Perhaps they hate themselves because they think that they should be able to know it all, convince others effortlessly, and attract the crowds by their spiritual superiority. Their pride is invested in their own way of doing and understanding things, and their investment is now threatened.

3. REJOICING IN THE MISORIENTATION: What emotions did I experience that drove me to act?

The story that we tell ourselves can generate a whole range of emotions. The disciples may be feeling anxiety over their limitations, frustration because they *should* be able to change the situation, dismay or embarrassment about their leader's decreasing popularity, or wrath and indignation because the situation is *unfair*. They are rejoicing in misoriented emotions that support their wobbling pride.

11. ACTION: What choices can I make based on the truth?

At this point, John's disciples switch from step 2 on the Judgment Path to step 11 on the Believe It Path. The emotions generated by their story invited them to take misoriented action, but now the quality of their training becomes evident. These disciples respond to their self-hate in a healthy way. They are willing to explore the Believe It Path, and they take action by talking to their teacher. Even though they may appear to be whining, they are at least engaging their teacher in a conversation which may reveal to them another perspective.

In this material world, we live on a timeline, so when we take a misoriented action, we cannot go back and undo the damage we have done; we have passed the point of no return. Misoriented actions always produce misoriented outcomes, and misoriented actions are the result of misoriented emotions. However, if we can recognize and humbly admit that our emotions are misoriented, we can choose to take oriented action instead of continuing down the Judgment Path and creating a mess. We can redirect our misoriented trail of cause and effect toward orientation.

Now look at John's response to his declining popularity. John takes the Believe It Path; he is a person of no fear. He has trained hard, so his fight is easy. Without the emotional turmoil generated by judgment, he simply believes the fact that the crowds are going to Jesus. Rather than trying to defend hurt pride, he rejoices in the truth of who God designed him to be. He experiences the secure confidence of having faithfully completed his mission. He feels joy over the rise of Jesus and embraces his own decline in popularity because he is not attached to an idealized outcome based on the illusion of personal superiority.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father, when things fall apart, guide me into believing it and trusting You. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some clean water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider a time when you were not or were no longer valued. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

Feelings

As you *consider a time when you were not or were no longer valued*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Gently hold this experience in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to push thoughts or feelings away, to judge them, or to justify them. We often flush real feelings or thoughts from our awareness before they have a chance to teach us and stretch us. Observe your thoughts and feelings without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider this time of not being valued*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* You might recognize what rage or abandonment feels like in your body. *(Pause)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to respectfully observe those uncomfortable sensations. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider not being valued*. Jesus knows what that feels like. *(Pause)* Do you judge not being valued by others as good or evil? *(Pause)* What do you believe when you see or feel that you are not valued? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Are you afraid of something? *(Pause)* Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

God created all of us to have these feelings, and for thousands of years human beings have had very strong feelings when they were not or were no longer valued. We all know what that feels like. *(Pause)* When these feelings are triggered, you can breathe rather than reacting and allowing yourself to get caught up in stories. You can let go of managing God's business. Breathe, and extend compassion to yourself and

others in this situation. Help your body process with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

(Optional) Continue to breathe while I test for further integration.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for this time together to train and to heal. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You guide us to our real glory and to the truth about who we are and what You would have us do. Lead us to the next step in our own healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self and mission, with our community and the rest of Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ www.centeringprayer.com.

² Ibid.

³ See KF16.

⁴ Dr. Roger Callahan, "TFT Stress Buster Tapping Class-Learn to Use TFT Tapping," Callahan Techniques, accessed April 24, 2016, www.rogercallahan.com/learn-to-tap.php. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven; en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tapas_Acupressure_Technique.